



**JABATAN PEMBANGUNAN KEMAHIRAN
KEMENTERIAN SUMBER MANUSIA
ARAS 7 & 8 BLOK D4, KOMPLEKS D
PUSAT PENTADBIRAN KERAJAAN PERSEKUTUAN
62530 PUTRAJAYA**

KERTAS PENERANGAN (INFORMATION SHEET)

KOD DAN NAMA PROGRAM / <i>PROGRAM CODE & NAME</i>	Z-009-3: 2015 CORE ABILITIES	
TAHAP / LEVEL	3 (THREE)	
NO. DAN TAJUK KEBOLEHAN TERAS / <i>CORE ABILITY NO. AND TITLE</i>	CA03 LEADERSHIP SKILLS	
NO. DAN PENYATAAN KEBOLEHAN / <i>ABILITY NO. AND STATEMENT</i>	03.01 DEMONSTRATE COUNSELLING ABILITIES 03.02 DEMONSTRATE RESPONSIBILITY & AUTHORITY ABILITIES 03.03 DEMONSTRATE TEAM WORK ABILITIES 03.04 DEMONSTRATE EMOTIONAL CONTROL IN CONFLICTS 03.05 APPLY WORK KNOWLEDGE IN IDENTIFYING CLIENT NEED 03.06 MONITOR WORK PERFORMANCE DELIVERY	
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TAJUK/TITLE : EMOTIONAL CONTROL AT WORK PLACE

TUJUAN/PURPOSE :

This Information Sheet is intended to describe the ability to counsel, lead, delegate, discuss solutions to conflict and identifying work targets and job performance. Trainee should be able to handle job coordination responsibly and lead his/her subordinates and/or peers to deliver work results in a controlled working environment.

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PENERANGAN/INFORMATION :

1 CONFLICTS IN THE WORKPLACE

- 1.1 Conflicts at the workplace can happen for many reasons. Some of the common types of conflicts are:
 - i) Role Conflicts – when roles and scopes of responsibilities clash
 - ii) Interpersonal Conflicts – when personalities and people clash
 - iii) External Conflicts – when your team or organization clashes with outsiders and their competing needs
 - iv) Direction Conflicts – when there's disagreement about the direction of the team or organization
 - v) Process Conflicts – when there's disagreement or disfunction in how things work in your team or organization
- 1.2 Conflicts are usually seen as a bad, destructive thing, and many indeed are. Frequent conflicts will almost certainly damage business performance and employee satisfaction.
- 1.3 However, conflicts are also a necessary part of working life, without which there can be no innovation, no growth and no change. "Good conflicts" are those which result in a net positive outcome in terms of change, growth or innovation.
- 1.4 As such, this section is meant to help supervisors to ensure that conflicts that occur do not deteriorate into "bad conflicts" with a net negative outcome, that "unnecessary conflicts" are reduced, and that the conflicts that do happen are channelled into opportunities for positive change or "good conflicts".
- 1.5 Tools to reduce "unnecessary conflicts" include
 - i) Basic Stress Management,
 - ii) Cultural Awareness
 - iii) Motivational Skills

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1.6 Tools to prevent conflicts from deteriorating into "bad conflicts" include

- i) Awareness of Personal Behaviours during conflicts

1.7 Tools to channel conflicts into "good conflicts" with positive opportunities are

- i) Problem Solving Skills
- ii) Counselling Abilities
- iii) Communication Skills
- iv) Coaching Skills

2 BASIC STRESS MANAGEMENT TO REDUCE UNNECESSARY CONFLICTS

2.1 "Unnecessary conflicts" often stem from poor stress management at the workplace. Some common workplace stressors are low salaries; excessive workloads; few opportunities for growth or advancement; fear of being laid-off; work that isn't engaging or challenging; lack of social support; not having enough control over job-related decisions; conflicting demands; being asked to work at optimum levels all the time; unclear performance expectations and many more.

2.2 Important steps you can take to reduce both your overall stress levels at work include:

- i) Recognizing your own signs of excessive stress, such as feeling anxious, irritable or depressed, muscle tension, headaches, stomach problems, fatigue, loss of sleep and so on.
- ii) Taking responsibility for restoring and improving your physical and emotional well-being being impacted by the stress, such as exercising, eating properly and sharing your feelings with a good listener.
- iii) Stay calm and patient. Check your reactions to the stress, and control negative attitudes and tendencies for knee-jerk reactions (like losing your temper) which adds more stress.
- iv) Adopt better communication skills and emotional intelligence to improve your relationship with management and co-workers
- v) Prioritize your work and organize yourself better. Don't overcommit yourself. Create a balanced schedule which includes personal time and regular breaks

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vi) Develop the capacity to meet challenges with appropriate humour.

2.3 As a supervisor, you can definitely lower the stress levels in your team by adopting practices such as:

- i) Improve and share communication, to remove uncertainty for your team members.
- ii) Consult your team and give them the opportunity to participate in decisions that affect their work lives.
- iii) Praise and recognize good performance, and try to publically reward and incentivize it.
- iv) Resolve conflicts positively. Resolving conflict in healthy, constructive ways can strengthen trust between people and reduce stress in the workplace.
- v) Cultivate a friendly social climate at work.

3 CULTURAL AWARENESS TO REDUCE UNNECESSARY CONFLICTS

3.1 Being a diverse nation, Malaysia is home to significant populations from different races and religions which are free practice their respective cultures. Additionally, there are more subtle cultural differences by state of origin, gender, age and by socio economic background too.

3.2 In such a situation, it is important that everyone practices Cultural Awareness in their daily interactions. This includes

- i) Understanding that our perception and reaction to things are already coloured by our own cultural values, and this may distort reality for us.
- ii) Appreciating that others value different things as much as we value what is important to us.
- iii) Understanding that what is considered appropriate in one culture may be considered inappropriate in another.

3.3 Without Cultural Awareness, conflicts can easily arise when cultures meet. Simple behaviours of the culturally ignorant can ignite anger and

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defensiveness in others, such as ridiculing others' beliefs, giving derogatory labels to others and pushing for your values to prevail over others'.

3.4 In order to reduce conflict in the workplace, supervisors should instill a overarching culture of fairness and mutual respect between different cultural groups in the workplace. Encourage team members to put themselves in others' shoes when acting or speaking, and avoid doing things which they would not like others to do to them. This creates empathy, which is one of the most effective conflict-retardants known to man.

4 MOTIVATIONAL SKILLS TO REDUCE "UNNECESSARY CONFLICTS"

4.1 Having good Motivational Skills is one of the biggest determinants of a good leader. Applying these skills is critical across most of the roles a leader plays.

4.2 In the context of reducing unnecessary conflicts, the Motivational Skill the leader should utilize is Positive Reinforcement, meaning publically recognizing and praising team members showing exemplary behaviour which retards conflicts including:

- i) Behaviours which avoided conflict
- ii) Behaviours which effectively resolved conflict for a win-win.
- iii) Strong team work within a team
- iv) Cooperation between teams
- v) Self sacrifice for the benefit of others.

4.3 Motivational Skills are also important when already in a conflict situation. A timely and inspiring talk by the leader can motivate members to set aside differences, and work towards the team vision and the mutual common good.

5 AWARENESS OF PERSONAL BEHAVIOURS TO PREVENT CONFLICTS FROM BECOMING "BAD CONFLICTS".

5.1 Conflicts can be about many things. But they are always fuelled by emotions. Otherwise, all parties would simply sit around a table, rational work out a win-

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win solution and there would be no more conflict! Of course, this is not about to happen.

- 5.2 If you are one of the parties in the conflict, you must be very self-aware of your own role in promoting or expanding the conflict. Honestly ask yourself if you are Escalating or De-Escalating the conflict, and be committed to behaviours which De-Escalate.
- 5.3 Some of the personal behaviours you should avoid during a conflict are
- i) Having strong views, without trying to explain them well, so that others can understand.
 - ii) Losing sight of the higher purpose, and going for small wins at all costs. This is what is meant by "winning the battle and losing the war".
 - iii) Saying too much and not controlling your words. Words cannot be retracted after they are said, and they can do lasting damage. So, before you say something, ask yourself, "Is this kind?", "Is this necessary?", "Do I know this to be really true?", "Am I going to regret saying this later?".
 - iv) Withholding a necessary apology. If you are in the wrong, apologize, even if you think the other party is wrong too. This already puts the conflict on the road to recovery. But make sure any apology is genuine. A half-hearted apology is the same or worse than not apologizing at all.
 - v) Lecturing the other party, and refusing to really listen to them.
 - vi) Needing to be always right or seeming to be always right. Properly explore what the other party is saying, and remember all the times you have been wrong before, before being confident of your case. In reality, the person who is always right, has stopped learning.
- 5.4 In order to check your own behaviours during a conflict, you must maintain a cool head, and full control over your emotions. You must find the still center within yourself which will allow you to have a detached look at your behaviour and the behaviour of others, and rationally decide on the best reaction to defuse the conflict in the best way. Imagine a blue desert oasis in a sandstorm; that is what you need to aim to create in yourself, during a conflict!

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6 PROBLEM-SOLVING SKILLS TO TURN CONFLICTS INTO "GOOD CONFLICTS"

6.1 Conflicts can become positive opportunities, when they deliver Win-Win outcomes, where both parties get what they want, or are able to compromise and still gain enough of what they each need.

6.2 Each conflict can result in one of the following outcomes.

- i) Win-Lose. This means that you Win and the other party Loses. While this may sound like a good outcome for you, it's bad for your relationships. Nobody likes to be made to lose, and they will resent and distrust you for it. Win-Lose is really only acceptable in sports and war.
- ii) Lose-Win. This means that you Lose and the other party Wins. While it's okay to give in on trivial matters, and even to sacrifice on important things once in a while, if you are regularly losing it means that you are not effectively standing up for yourself. You will end up being taken advantage of and resenting your situation.
- iii) Lose-Lose. Both parties lose as a result of the conflict. This is the worst scenario and should be avoided. Examples of lose-lose is having an emotional fight in the office which is embarrassing to both parties, and taking part in revenge or tit-for-tat behaviour which results in a cycle of losing for both parties.
- iv) Win-Win. This is the outcome which both parties in the conflict should strive for, in order for either party to enjoy a true, lasting win. This means striving for outcomes where both parties get what they want, or compromise but are still happy with what they get. It means having the kind of mindset which is caring towards the other party in the conflict, and which believes that there is enough success for everyone to share. Examples of Win-Win involves acknowledging other team's contributions towards your team's win and exchanging resources between teams to support the team with the most pressing need.

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6.3 In order to achieve the Win-Win outcome, both leaders and team members should learn and apply good Problem-Solving Skills during a conflict. This is a big topic, but two of the most basic problem-solving skills are:

- i) Applying the right Process for problem-solving. The process is typically split into 5 parts, and applied whether you are trying to solve the problem yourself or in a group:
 - a) Define the problem and state the ideal solutions wanted by all parties. This practice itself sheds new light which really aids in problem-solving.
 - b) Exploring information and create ideas / alternatives.
 - c) Select the best idea / alternative
 - d) Create a plan and apply the idea / alternative
 - e) Evaluate the results

- i) Applying suitable Tools for exploring and creating viable ideas / alternatives. Some of the most used tools are:
 - a) Brainstorming: A group suggests a large number of solutions or ideas, and combine and develop them until an optimum solution is found
 - b) Root Cause Analysis: Identifying all the causes of a problem. This starts with creating a timeline of events culminating with the crisis / problem. Then ask “Why did this happen?” against each of events which contributed to the end problem. For each factor causing the event, ask another why, and another why, until you reach the root cause. Repeat this with the other events until you have a view of all root causes. Come up with changes which will remove the root causes, and other problems along the way.
 - c) Research and Analogy: Investigate similar situations (for example through reading, interviewing experienced people) and use a solution that has solved an analogous problem.

6.4 Problem Solving Skills is just like any other skills. The more you practice, the better you get!

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7 COMMUNICATION SKILLS, COUNSELLING ABILITIES AND COACHING ABILITIES TO TURN CONFLICTS INTO "GOOD CONFLICTS"

- 7.1 In a conflict situation, a Supervisor will often have to play the role of mediator to help solve the conflict. This may done with each party of the conflict separately, or together, and should be run along the lines of the counselling session which has been covered in the Counselling Abilities section of this module.
- 7.2 The Supervisor must aim to exercise the Counselling Abilities, Communication Skills and Coaching Skills covered in that section.
- 7.3 Additionally, remember that whatever the reason for the conflict, once the conflict is happening, it is being fueled by emotions. Address these emotions in the room, using the skills in 7.2, and the conflict will start to cool down, and the stage set for finding the win-win. The main emotions in play are:
- i) Need for Appreciation. Everyone needs to feel appreciated for who they are and what they have contributed. Remember to show appreciation.
 - ii) Need for Affiliation. Everyone needs to feel that they belong. So emphasize the connections and commonality between the parties.
 - iii) Need for Autonomy. Everyone needs to feel that they are trusted to make their own decision and be independent. So involve the parties in the resolution and show them trust to decide on what is best.
 - iv) Need for Role and Status. Everyone needs to feel recognized, in charge and important within their sphere. So ensure that due regard and respect is being shown to the role and status of each party.
- 7.4 A Supervisor who is willing the play the mediator role, and apply the right Problem Solving Skills, Counselling Abilities, Communication Skills and Coaching Skills, will find the conflicts within his/her team not only being resolved satisfactorily, but becoming a useful source of improvement, ideas and innovation for his/her team. In other words, a "good conflict" to have!

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SOALAN/QUESTION :

1. What are the 5 typical types of conflicts which occur in the workplace?

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2. All conflicts can end in one of 4 kinds of outcomes. What are they?

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3. What are the 5 stages of the typical Problem-Solving process?

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RUJUKAN / REFERENCES:

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